finances will be a major challenge given the heavy debt the previous Congress government has left the state with, in no small measure due to spending on whimsical projects. In the past, she has taken up the demands of her constituents strongly with ministers and officials and so knows well how the system works.

The other deputy CM, P.C. Bairwa, gets higher and technical education, transport and ayurveda. Another notable appointee: six-time MLA and RSS man Madan Dilawar, who gets panchayati raj and school education (the latter a special interest area of the Sangh). Ex-Union minister Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore gets industries, commerce, IT and a few other challenging portfolios. Six-term MLA Kirori Lal Meena gets agriculture, rural development and three other portfolios. The party has tried a caste balance, making for a rainbow representation in the administrative divisions.

NEWLY MINTED CM BHAJAN LAL WILL BE HOPING TO AVOID SLIP-UPS LIKE THE KARANPUR BYPOLL THIS ELECTION YEAR

As for the bureaucracy, PM Narendra Modi last week cautioned against mass transfers. The BJP top brass has handpicked former Union health secretary Sudhansh Pant as the new chief secretary. He will have a three-year tenure before superannuation, ample time to bring some efficiency to a notoriously casual bureaucracy. DGP Umesh Mishra has been given marching orders, with U.R. Sahoo, sidelined by the Congress government, taking his place. All that's part of a larger plan. Bhajan Lal's immediate focus will be to fast-track 'Modi's guarantee' to ensure the BJP has a firm grip over Rajasthan's 25 Lok Sabha seats. The new CM cannot afford to let the party stumble like in Karanpur. ■

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



THE HORROR
Bilkis Bano

BILKIS BANO CASE

SUSPENSION OF DISBELIEF

By Jumana Shah

The new year has brought a glimmer of hope for 2002 Gujarat riots case victim Bilkis Bano. But when the Supreme Court on January 8 set aside the remission granted to the 11 convicted for gang-raping her and killing 14 members of her family, the symbolic freight it carried went well beyond the tale of individual fates. Coming in the year of a general election, it's bound to have a political edge—though it's difficult to say which way it will cut.

Overturning the Gujarat government's August 2022 decision, the SC rapped the state for "acting in tandem" with the convicts and pulling a "fraud" on the court. The state was not the competent authority to decide on the remission issue, it said, as the case was tried and convicted in a special CBI court in Maharashtra in 2008.

The SC order, signed by Justices B.V. Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan, used the word 'fraud' 25 times and explained in detail the sequence of events that led to the remission, aided by a May 2022 order "fraudulently obtained at the hands of this Court" by "suppression and misrepresentation of material facts". The court ordered the convicts to report to jail within two weeks and serve their remaining sentence.

The release of the convicts in August '22, just months before the Gujarat election, had caused widespread outrage. The ball had been set rolling in 2019 when, after serving 14 years and five months, convict